

GAME 5 COACH GAMEPLAN

San Antonio Spurs vs. New York Knicks

Elimination game | New York leads 3-1 | Data cutoff: through Game 4

CORE VERDICT

Protect the good minutes. Remove the fragile ones.

+47

Q1 margin

-55

Q2-Q4 margin

+11 / -19

Wemby on / off

+30 pts

NYK corner-3 edge

What wins Game 5

Keep the starting structure, match Wembanyama to Towns, remove extended Fox-Castle-Harper overlap, turn paint touches into corner threes, and use an automatic response package when the game begins to drift.

Coach summary

- The opening plan worked: San Antonio won every first quarter and its most-used starting lineup was +12.
- The failure came after the opening phase: later quarters erased the early advantage, the non-Wembanyama stretches were negative, and fourth-quarter turnovers doubled New York's total.
- New York's advantage was stability through Towns, secondary efficiency, corner threes, rebounding, and closing execution.

Defining question

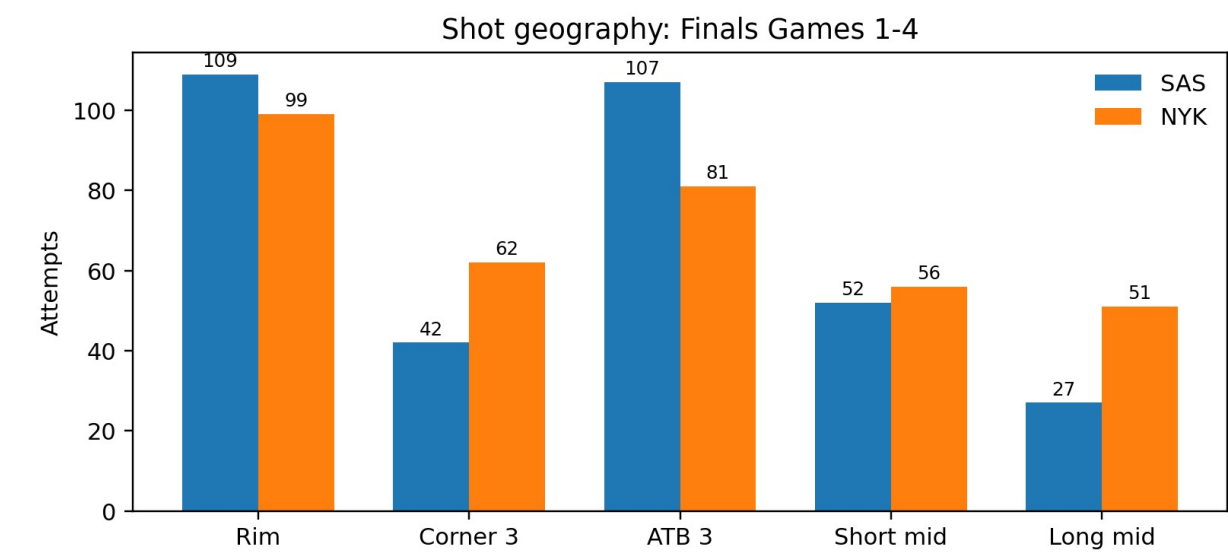
Did San Antonio maintain possession quality and lineup stability for all 48 minutes?

Offensive game plan

Objective
Create the first advantage with Fox and Wembanyama, then finish at the rim, the line, or the corners.

Three offensive priorities

#	Priority	Coach response	Live KPI
1	Create earlier Wembanyama decisions	Early drag screens, empty-side Fox-Wemby actions, quick seals, slips, rolls, short-roll passing. Reduce static late-clock perimeter creation.	Paint touch, foul, or advantage pass first; Wemby 3PA below ~30% of FGA.
2	Turn paint pressure into corner threes	Drive-roll-skip, baseline drift, corner lifts, second-side attacks. Use Vassell and Champagne as spacing beneficiaries.	At least 35% of SAS 3PA from corners; short midrange below 12% of FGA.
3	Use Fox as the advantage creator	Turn the corner, force the second defender to commit, make the simple read. Reduce unsupported pull-ups.	Fox AST:TOV at least 2:1; no more than 3 SAS Q4 turnovers.



Evidence: NYK generated 20 more corner threes and a 30-point corner-three advantage. SAS had 26 more above-the-break attempts.

Process, not volume
San Antonio already reached the rim. The correction is to force one more rotation after the paint touch.

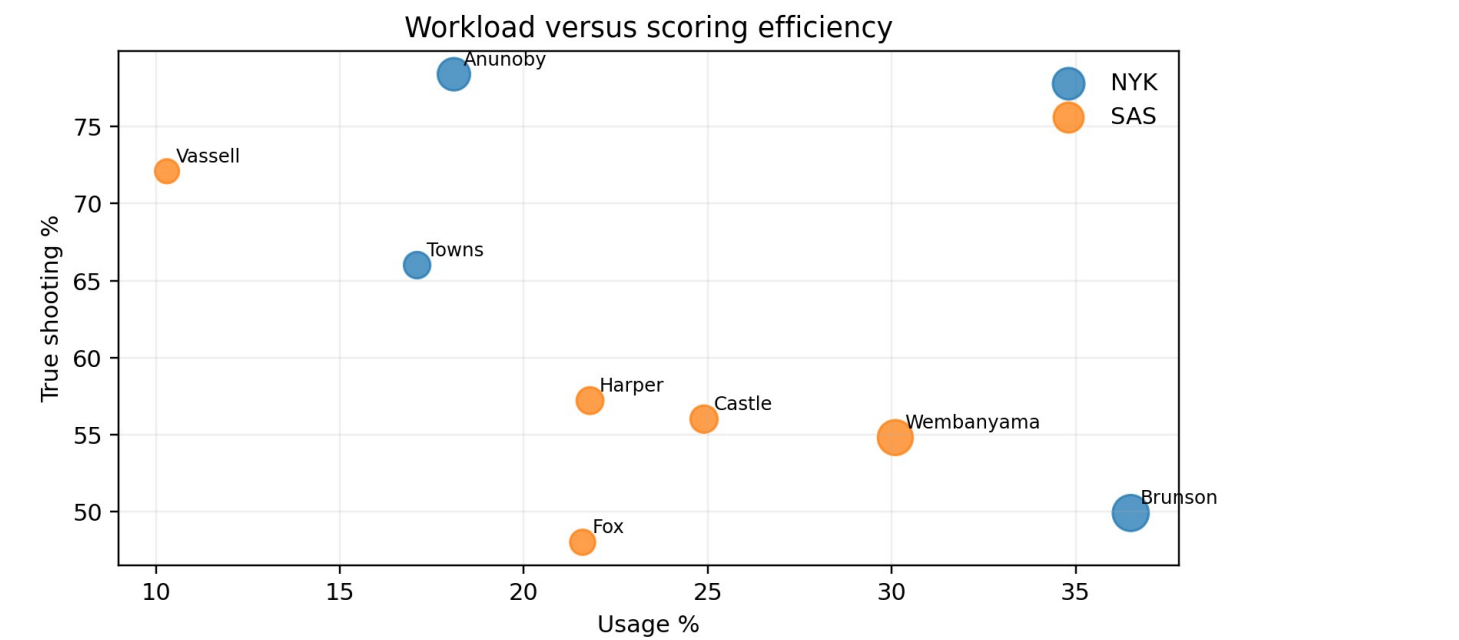
Defensive game plan

Objective

Keep Brunson in difficult individual offense without releasing Towns, Anunoby, offensive rebounds, and corner threes.

Three defensive priorities

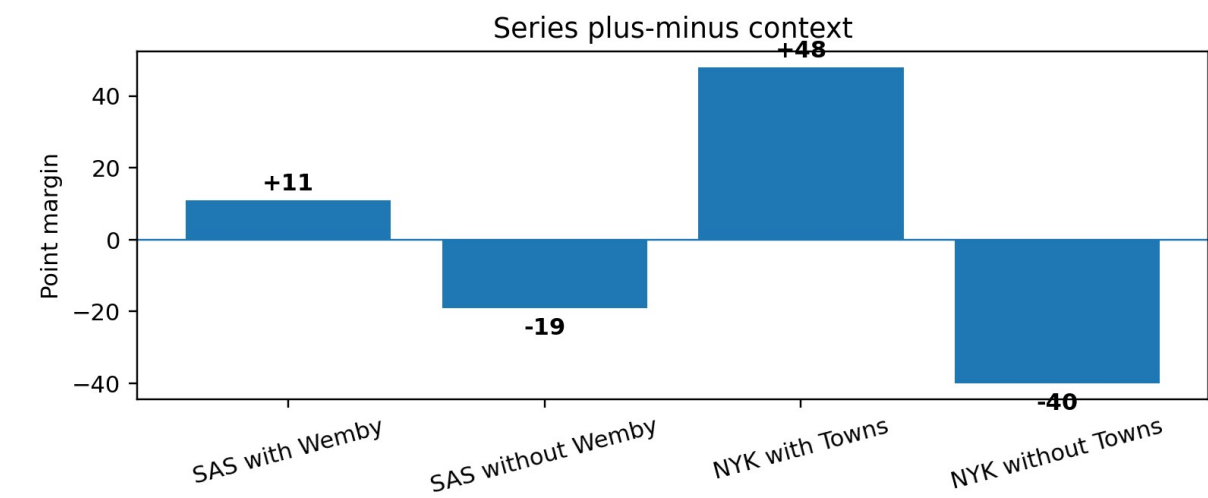
#	Priority	Coach response	Live KPI
1	Contain Brunson without overhelping	Keep size on him, show help late, recover quickly. Do not automatically send a second defender after a difficult make.	Stay when Brunson is inefficient and secondary creation remains controlled.
2	Match Wembanyama to Towns	Cover every Towns stint with Wembanyama when possible. Stay connected to the pop and assign the weak-side box-out.	NYK OREB% below 30%; no repeated Towns pops, seals, or putbacks.
3	Protect rim and corners first	Tag the roll without abandoning the strong-side corner; execute early x-outs; concede selected long twos/ATB threes.	NYK near 12 or fewer corner 3PA; no quarter with 3+ offensive rebounds.



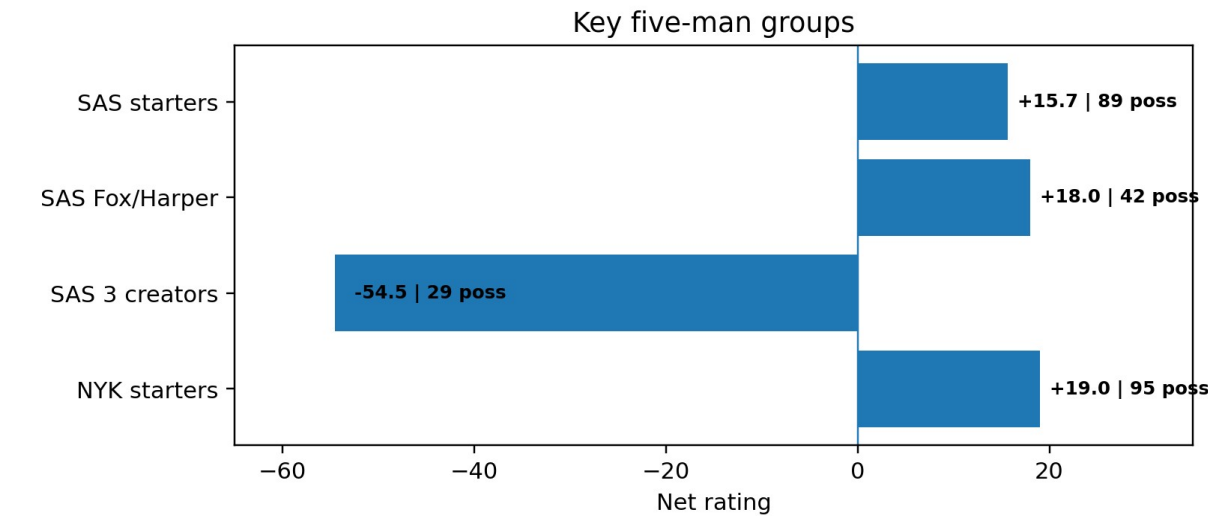
Evidence: Brunson carried the workload at 49.9 TS%; Towns and Anunoby delivered the efficient secondary outcomes.

BRUNSON 29.5 PPG 36.5 USG% 49.9 TS% 4.0 TOV Verdict: difficult high-volume pressure, not dominant efficiency.	TOWNS 15.8 PPG 66.0 TS% +48 total margin Verdict: the central matchup and rotation target.
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Rotation and matchup plan



Series context: Wembanyama's minutes were positive, San Antonio's rest minutes were negative, and Towns' on/off profile made him the central matchup axis.



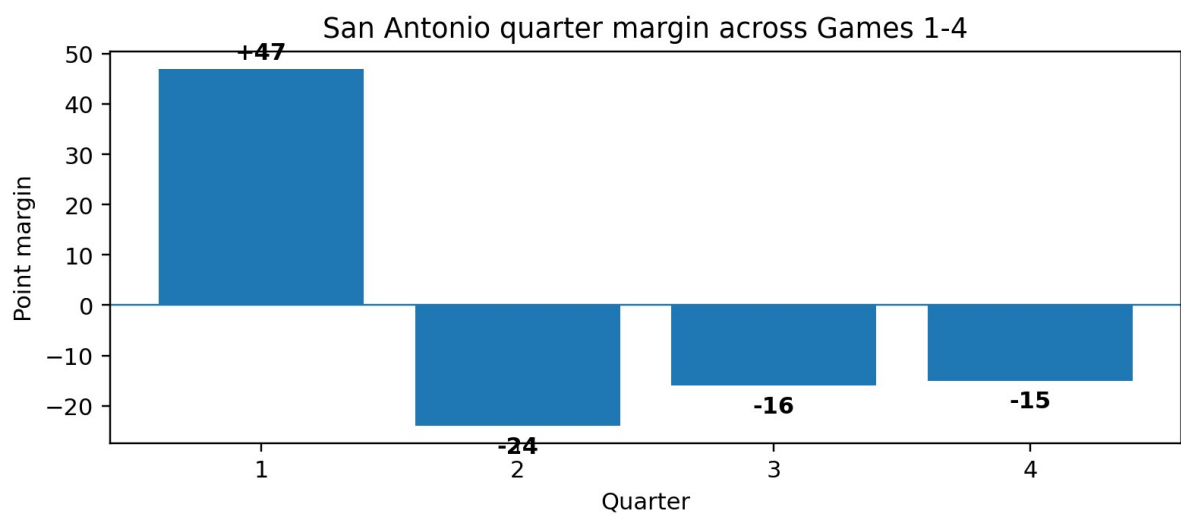
The same three-creator lineup was -17 in raw plus-minus and -54.5 per 100 possessions over 29 possessions. Those are different measures of the same lineup, not conflicting results.

Decision	Instruction	Evidence
Start / close	Fox-Vassell-Champagnie-Wembanyama-Castle	115.7 ORTG, 100.0 DRTG, +12
Primary alternate	Fox-Vassell-Champagnie-Wembanyama-Harper	+12 over 42 possessions
Limit	Fox-Vassell-Wembanyama-Castle-Harper	-17 raw plus-minus; -54.5 net rating over 29 possessions
Wembanyama	Target 42-44 min; cover every Towns stint	Keep rests short; end a rapid -4 stint
Backup center	Kornet situational, not automatic	SAS -19 in his 31.4 minutes
Foul-trouble fallback	If Wembanyama has 2 fouls in Q1 or 3 before halftime, abandon the 42-44 minute target. Bank his remaining first-half minutes for Towns and use only short backup stints.	Use Kornet with Fox or Vassell plus two spacers; sit Wembanyama when Towns sits whenever possible.

Lineup rule

Two creators, two spacers/finishers, and Wembanyama. Avoid extended three-creator overlap when structure is slipping.

Game management and run response



The opening plan worked. San Antonio's advantage disappeared after the first quarter.

How each game turned

G1	SAS 9-0 -> takes 95-94 lead	→	NYK closes 11-0
G2	SAS 14-0 -> ties at 97	→	NYK wins 105-104
G3	SAS 6-0 early Q4 -> +7	→	SAS protects lead
G4	SAS +27 at halftime	→	NYK 8-0 late -> takes lead

Both teams created 16 major runs. New York's edge was timing and completion, not run volume.

Automatic response package

Trigger	Any NYK 6-0 run, a -4 non-Wemby swing, or the third SAS fourth-quarter turnover.
Lineup	Return to the preferred balanced group; remove creator overlap.
Offense	Call the preselected Fox-Wembanyama action on the next two half-court possessions.
Defense	Name the lowest-priority Knicks shooter; restate low-man, x-out, and rebound assignments.

Timeout principle

The timeout is not the adjustment. The lineup, action, coverage, and rebound assignments are the adjustment.

Game 5 bench scorecard

Track these indicators live. They define whether the plan is working.

Measure	Target	Evidence
Shot quality	At least 35% of SAS threes from corners	NYK held a 30-point corner-three edge.
Ball security	No more than 3 SAS Q4 turnovers	SAS 16 Q4 turnovers; NYK 8.
Wemby rest	No non-Wemby stint worse than -4	The series margin was lost during Wembanyama's rest minutes.
Towns matchup	Wembanyama covers every Towns stint	NYK +48 with Towns, -40 without.
Rebounding	NYK OREB% below 30%	NYK led 31.2% to 27.0%.
Brunson discipline	No coverage change on difficult makes alone	29.5 PPG, but 49.9 TS%.
Fox creation	At least 2:1 AST:TOV	Creation is the better path than forced scoring.
Closing group	Preferred balanced five for final 5:00	Late leads were lost in Games 1 and 4.

Do not overreact to

- A difficult Brunson make.
- One missed corner three after a good possession.
- A single poor Wembanyama touch.
- One small-sample lineup result without matching film.

Change immediately when

- The non-Wemby group loses four points quickly.
- NYK creates four corner threes in a quarter.
- NYK records three offensive rebounds in a quarter.
- SAS reaches three fourth-quarter turnovers.
- The Fox-Castle-Harper group loses spacing or hierarchy.

Acceptable concession

Contested Brunson pull-up twos and selected above-the-break attempts. Do not trade those shots for Towns efficiency, offensive rebounds, or clean corner threes.

Evidence against the plan and remaining uncertainty

Why this matters		
The recommendation follows the strongest evidence, but four games of public data cannot identify every tactical cause.		
Constraint		Implication
Small sample		Quarter and lineup swings may include shooting variance.
Lineup causality		The three-creator result is a warning, not proof of permanent incompatibility.
Towns on/off		The +48/-40 context includes teammate, opponent, and timing effects.
Anunoby conflict		78.4 TS% with negative total plus-minus shows scoring efficiency is not complete impact.
Rim frequency		SAS already reached the rim; the correction concerns the final shot after the paint touch.
Timeouts		Earlier stoppages alone are not supported; runs continued through timeouts.
Starting lineup		The starters were good, so a dramatic lineup change contradicts the evidence.
Film requirement		Exact coverages, screen locations, help rules, and Wemby play types require possession review.

Pregame verdict

San Antonio does not need a new winning identity. It needs to preserve the identity that already produced dominant first quarters, positive starting minutes, and positive Wembanyama minutes. The elimination-game correction is to reduce unstable rest and creator-overlap periods, protect the rim and corners without overreacting to Brunson's difficult makes, and use Fox-Wembanyama structure to create better final shots and cleaner closing possessions.

Defining Game 5 question	
Did San Antonio maintain possession quality and lineup stability for all 48 minutes?	